

The Consent Gap

Governments are linking their citizens' records into single profiles — and nobody was asked.

One tool, one window into a global default. *Splink* — a free record-linkage program built by the UK Ministry of Justice — joins a person's separate records across government where there is no shared ID. Everything below is from the institutions' own published documents.

1. They linked 56 million people — silently. The UK Office for National Statistics linked the **2021 Census to DWP benefits and HMRC tax records** — **96.7%, ~56 million people**. No individual consent. No notification. No opt-out. (*ONS, 2021*

Census↔DWP/NINo methodology)

2. It's no longer just statistics — it's identifying named individuals. The Ministry of Justice uses it **in real time in court**, and "to find **Police National Computer numbers** associated with individuals, in order to request relevant arrest information from the police." (*GOV.UK Algorithmic Transparency Record — MoJ Splink Master Record*)

3. It now reaches the most vulnerable people alive. Documented users include **UNHCR (refugee data)**, the **Shared Child Health Record in Laos**, and the **2024 Gambian census**. (*Splink official Use Cases*)

4. It's not one country. Confirmed government use across **~8 countries plus the EU and the UN** — UK, Australia, **Germany (Destatis)**, USA (Defense Health Agency, 200M+ records), **Canada** (Ontario; Environment Canada), Chile, Gambia, Laos, the **European Medicines Agency, UNHCR**. And that is only who *published* it. (*Splink official Use Cases*)

5. The bigger truth: this is the new normal. **~54% of UNECE countries already build their census on linked administrative data; ~half go fully register-based by 2030.** The Nordics have for decades. OECD and the UN endorse it "subject to safeguards." (*UNECE 2020 census round; OECD/UN guidance*)

6. The legal basis is the scandal. None of this is illegal. It runs on **statute, not consent**. Which means the consent gap isn't a few bad actors — it's **structural**, the default setting of the modern state, expanding toward total coverage.

The line that doesn't move:

Your records — health, tax, justice, benefits — are being joined into a single profile of you, lawfully, across most of the developed world. You were never asked. You cannot say no. And almost no one was told.

Full report & archived evidence: brandonmyers.net/writing/the-quiet-joining-up · Sources: GOV.UK Algorithmic Transparency Records, ONS, Splink official documentation, UNECE, OECD. Compiled 4 June 2026.